reach them because of their location. The huge wall of the hotel was preventing the fire trucks from coming close enough. Faced with this situation, Thevar rushed the couple back through the room and down the stairs as the fire raced towards them, just managing to outpace the flames. After reaching near the ground floor, they crawled out through an AC duct, he says.

Throughout this harrowing time, the young butler was aware that he was courting death. He could have escaped, but decided to stay with the terrified couple. The Swiss husband and wife were so thankful that they later asked the hotel management for Thevar's details and sent him presents and money to buy himself a Bullet motorbike.

This extraordinary behaviour of the staff that did not fit into any known behavioural pattern received worldwide attention. Intrigued by their selfless commitment, Deshpande did a case study of their response to analyse the reasons behind their astonishing show of courage.

Using the module for analyses in his classes, he made it a practice to ask his students to guess how many of the staff would have fled the scene in the face of the attack. The students were astounded when they were told that no one did.

The professor sought to understand the staff's behaviour through the Taj's recruitment process, the training it imparted and its rewards programme. He found out that the Taj recruited employees from semi-urban cities and small towns, as people there were more likely to have old-world values. In those towns, the hotel's hospitality team would interact with potential candidates and look for those who exhibited 'personal characteristics … most specifically, respect and empathy'.

As Deshpande said, in a country where placements are dependent on high grades, the Tatas recruited for 'character'. He reasoned that they focused mainly on 'building a customer-centric culture and value system'. The staff was motivated to look at every interaction with a guest as an opportunity to 'delight' them with kindness. Deshpande concluded that ultimately, during the dreadful three-day siege, the employees were 'essentially performing the behaviours they were selected and trained to perform. In this case, extreme kindness to customers'.

However, even after the elaborate study, Deshpande acknowledged that he did not have a definitive explanation for the selfless manner in which the staff had acted during the crisis. He said, 'This example far exceeds